# CORPORATE COGNITIVE WARFARE

*Irregular Warfare for Market Supremacy*

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## About This Edition

This is the expanded edition of the white paper *Corporate Cognitive Warfare: Irregular Warfare for Market Supremacy*, written by William Aaron Turner, Founder and President of Infinitum Corporation, who coined the term "Corporate Cognitive Warfare" in 2026. The original approved paper set out the doctrine in brief. This edition keeps its structure, its definitions and its six-phase framework. It adds four bodies of material: a doctrinal foundation drawn from published military literature, detailed corporate applications for each technique, an extended set of illustrative use cases, and a dedicated section on defense and counter-influence.

**Neutrality statement.** The military material in Section 2 presents doctrinal approaches analytically. It describes what published sources say about how different military traditions think about perception, decision-making and influence. It takes no side and makes no claim about any party, and it does not praise, blame or score any state, army, government or leader. Where the analytic literature on a concept comes mainly from outside the tradition that produced it, the paper says so. Accounts of particular campaigns or attributions of specific operations are deliberately left out. The paper is about concepts and their lessons for organizations, not about conflicts.

**Ethics statement.** Every corporate application in this paper is meant to be used within the law and within the rules of the platforms involved. That means truthful advertising, clear disclosure of paid and material relationships, respect for privacy law, and authentic accounts and engagement. Deceptive tactics such as fake accounts, bot networks, astroturfing, fabricated reviews and disinformation are described only as threats to recognize and defend against. The paper gives no instructions for using them.

**Illustrative material.** The use cases in Section 5 are composites written to show how the doctrine applies. They do not describe real clients, real campaigns or results achieved by Infinitum Corporation.

**Sources.** Every source cited here is public and was checked before release: journal articles by DOI, and reports, statutes and policies at their official URLs. Quotations are reproduced as they appear in the cited source. The full list is in the References section.

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## Executive Summary

Corporate Cognitive Warfare is the deliberate application of irregular warfare principles—guerrilla tactics, psychological operations, influence campaigns, algorithmic manipulation, and asymmetric information dominance—to the corporate competitive environment. Coined by William Aaron Turner, the term describes a strategic paradigm in which organizations treat the cognitive space of customers, employees, investors, competitors, and regulators as a contested battlespace.

Unlike conventional marketing, Corporate Cognitive Warfare seeks not merely to promote products but to shape how target audiences perceive reality, make decisions, and allocate attention and resources. It operates below the threshold of open conflict, using adaptive, low-signature methods to achieve durable cognitive advantage. Throughout this paper, "low-signature" means quiet, efficient and well-targeted. It never means hidden from the audience in ways the law or platform rules require to be disclosed.

This white paper defines the doctrine, maps irregular warfare techniques onto corporate applications, and provides a practical framework for both offensive employment and defensive resilience. It emphasizes ethical boundaries, legal compliance, and the long-term strategic value of trust preservation.

The expanded edition develops that argument in five ways.

First, it grounds the concept in military doctrine. Militaries in several traditions concluded long ago that perception and decision-making are decisive terrain. Soviet and Russian writers developed *reflexive control*, the theory of conveying "specially prepared information" to incline an opponent "to voluntarily make the predetermined decision" (Chotikul 1986). Chinese military writers have developed the "three warfares" of public opinion, psychological and legal warfare, and more recently *cognitive domain operations*, a concept that analysts describe as seeking "mind superiority" (Kania 2016; Beauchamp-Mustafaga 2019). NATO's scientific community now treats cognitive warfare as an area of study in its own right and stresses resilience as a primary response (NATO STO n.d.). These traditions differ in vocabulary and purpose. All of them treat the human mind as terrain. Section 2 presents them neutrally, from published sources, and draws out lessons that transfer to commercial competition.

Second, it gives detailed, lawful corporate applications for each of the five core techniques: guerrilla marketing, marketing psychological operations (persuasion psychology), algorithmic optimization (what the original paper calls algorithmic manipulation), social influence and targeted advertising. Each application comes with the legal and platform rules that bound it, including the U.S. Federal Trade Commission's Endorsement Guides and its 2024 rule on consumer reviews and testimonials, the EU General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) and Digital Services Act (DSA), and the California Consumer Privacy Act (CCPA).

Third, it sets out twelve illustrative use cases. They range from a challenger reframing a category to a firm defending itself against a fake-review attack or an executive deepfake.

Fourth, it adds a defensive doctrine. The same techniques that win attention can be turned against an organization by competitors, activists, fraudsters or opportunists, and the illegitimate versions—coordinated inauthentic behavior, bot networks, fabricated reviews, impersonation and disinformation—are now routine risks. Section 6 shows how to detect, withstand and answer them, drawing on research on psychological inoculation and misinformation correction.

Fifth, it turns the doctrine into an operating model: roles, gates, metrics, a 90-day start-up plan and a maturity path.

Key takeaways:

- The decisive terrain in modern markets is cognitive. Attention, trust and the framing of choices often decide outcomes before price or features are compared.
- Military doctrine offers a disciplined vocabulary for that terrain: modeling how the other side reasons, shaping the frame in which decisions are made, contesting narratives, and building resilience against hostile influence.
- In commerce, the advantage is durable only when it is earned with truthful claims, disclosed relationships, authentic engagement and respect for privacy. Deception is a strategic liability as well as a legal one.
- Every organization is already a target. A cognitive defense capability—monitoring, prebunking, rapid and accurate response, and decision hygiene—is now basic organizational hygiene.
- Smaller organizations can win. Asymmetry favors the side that understands the audience best and moves fastest, not the side that spends most.

# 1. Defining Corporate Cognitive Warfare

Corporate Cognitive Warfare is irregular warfare conducted in the commercial domain. It is the systematic effort to gain, maintain, and protect cognitive superiority over relevant audiences in order to advance organizational objectives—market share, valuation, talent acquisition, regulatory outcomes, or competitive displacement.

## 1.1 Origin of the Term

William Aaron Turner coined the term "Corporate Cognitive Warfare" in 2026 to name a reality he saw in modern markets and in the security work Infinitum Corporation does. Organizations already compete through attention, belief and decision-making, yet most of them manage those contests piecemeal: brand in one department, communications in another, competitive intelligence in a third, and trust and safety, if it exists, somewhere else. The term pulls these activities into a single discipline with a single question: what do the people who matter to us believe, why do they believe it, and how is that belief being contested?

The word "warfare" is used deliberately and analytically. It signals that the cognitive environment is contested, that other actors are working to shape the same audiences, and that some of them do not follow the rules. It does not license treating customers as enemies, and it does not license deception. The military vocabulary is a lens for disciplined thinking about competition, in the same way that strategy, campaigns, intelligence and logistics long ago became ordinary management language.

## 1.2 Key Characteristics

Key characteristics include:

- Asymmetry: smaller or agile actors can challenge larger incumbents by targeting decision-making processes rather than resources.
- Ambiguity of signature: much cognitive competition looks like normal business activity—a well-timed article, a product demonstration, a talk at an industry event—so its strategic intent is not

obvious to observers. In lawful practice, that ambiguity concerns strategy only. It never extends to hiding who is speaking or who paid.

- Cognitive focus: success is measured by changed beliefs, priorities, and behaviors, not just awareness or clicks.
- Continuum of competition: activity persists across peacetime marketing, crisis response, and contested markets.
- Multi-audience terrain: customers, employees, investors, partners, regulators, journalists and analysts all hold beliefs that matter, and what is said to one audience reaches the others.
- Machine-mediated reach: most messages now arrive through ranking and recommendation systems, and increasingly through generative AI answers, so understanding those systems is part of understanding the terrain.

## 1.3 What Corporate Cognitive Warfare Is Not

Because the vocabulary is martial, it is worth being precise about the boundaries.

It is not disinformation. Disinformation is false information knowingly shared to cause harm (Wardle and Derakhshan 2017). A company that spreads falsehoods about a competitor exposes itself to false-advertising liability and to the collapse of the trust it was trying to win.

It is not coordinated inauthentic behavior. Major platforms define and remove networks that use fake identities to mislead people about who is behind them (Meta n.d.; X Corp. n.d.). Such networks are threats to defend against, not tools.

It is not covert. Commercial influence must be identifiable as such where the law requires it. Paid endorsements carry disclosures, sponsored content is labeled, and executives speak in their own names.

It is not exploitation of the vulnerable. Targeting children, people in crisis or people with sensitive characteristics with manipulative techniques is unethical and, in many jurisdictions, unlawful.

What it is: a structured way to understand the cognitive terrain, frame choices truthfully and compellingly, win attention through legitimate means, build credible advocates, and defend the organization's reputation and decision-making against hostile influence.

## 1.4 The Cognitive Terrain: Five Audiences

The original paper names customers, employees, investors, competitors and regulators. Each is a distinct piece of terrain with its own beliefs, information pathways and decision rules.

**Customers** decide on the basis of perceived value, perceived risk and identity. In business-to-business markets, the "customer" is a buying committee whose members hold different fears: the finance lead fears overspending, the technical lead fears failure, the executive sponsor fears reputational embarrassment. Each fear can be addressed truthfully with its own evidence.

**Employees and candidates** decide where to work, how hard to work and whether to stay, based on beliefs about mission, fairness, stability and prospects. They are also the organization's most credible messengers and its most likely leak path.

**Investors and lenders** price narrative as well as numbers. Their beliefs about strategy, management credibility and risk affect the cost of capital. Public companies must also manage this audience within securities disclosure rules such as Regulation FD (17 CFR Part 243).

**Competitors** are an audience too. Their beliefs about a firm's intentions, capabilities and resolve shape their pricing, product and entry decisions. Clear, public, truthful signals—such as a credible commitment to a market—can deter wasteful competition. This is the lawful commercial counterpart of the military idea of shaping an opponent's decisions, and Section 2 explores it.

**Regulators and policymakers** form views about an industry from evidence, testimony and public sentiment. Engaging them lawfully means transparent advocacy, registered lobbying where required, and honest data.

A sixth group cuts across all five: **intermediaries**—journalists, analysts, creators, review platforms and, increasingly, AI assistants that summarize what the web says about a company. Intermediaries are force multipliers and cannot be controlled. They can only be informed, engaged and, where they err, corrected.

### 1.5 The Doctrinal Lineage in Brief

Military and strategic traditions worldwide have long recognized the decisive role of influencing how opponents perceive situations and make decisions. Russian military thought developed the concept of reflexive control—the process of conveying specially prepared information so that an adversary voluntarily makes decisions favorable to the initiator. Chinese military writings have elaborated cognitive domain operations as a distinct battlespace aimed at shaping cognition, will, and decision-making across peacetime and conflict. These approaches treat human cognition itself as contested terrain and provide doctrinal foundations that can be adapted to corporate environments.

Further reading: Russia's Reflexive Control Theory and the Military | How China Wins the Cognitive Domain (CASI)

## 2. Theoretical and Historical Foundations

### 2.1 Irregular Warfare Principles

Classical irregular warfare emphasizes population-centric operations, guerrilla tactics, intelligence-driven targeting, and the erosion of an adversary's will and legitimacy. Mao, Galula, and modern special operations doctrine all stress that the decisive terrain is human cognition and social cohesion. Corporate Cognitive Warfare imports these principles into markets where attention, trust, and narrative legitimacy are the scarce resources.

The U.S. Department of Defense's 2020 summary of its Irregular Warfare Annex describes irregular warfare as a struggle among state and non-state actors to influence populations and affect legitimacy, favoring indirect and asymmetric approaches (U.S. DoD 2020). Two elements of that description carry straight into commerce. The first is *legitimacy*. In a market, legitimacy is the belief that a company has the right to be chosen: it is credible, it is trustworthy, it belongs in the consideration set. The second is *indirect approach*. Irregular actors rarely meet a stronger opponent head-on. They change the terms of the contest instead.

Mao's writings on guerrilla warfare, translated by Samuel B. Griffith and reprinted by the U.S. Marine Corps as FMFRP 12-18, stress the guerrilla's dependence on the population and the importance of choosing when and where to engage (Mao 1961/1989). David Galula's *Counterinsurgency Warfare: Theory and Practice* (1964) approaches the same problem from the other side and treats the population's support as the objective of the whole contest. A corporate strategist does not need to adopt either author's politics to see the point: the side with the people's trust can operate where the other cannot.

Four irregular-warfare principles translate into corporate practice:

- **The population is the objective.** Market share follows belief. Campaigns that win clicks but lose trust are tactical victories and strategic defeats.
- **Intelligence precedes action.** Irregular forces survive on superior knowledge of local terrain. In commerce, that means knowing the audience's language, fears, informal leaders and information habits better than the competitor does.
- **Concentrate where the opponent is weak.** A challenger should fight in the segment, channel or narrative the incumbent neglects, not where the incumbent's budget is strongest.
- **Legitimacy is the center of gravity.** An irregular actor that loses legitimacy loses its base. A company caught deceiving loses customers, partners, regulators and staff at the same moment.

## 2.2 From Military Cognitive Warfare to the Boardroom

Military cognitive warfare seeks to degrade an opponent's decision-making, cohesion, and willingness to contest. In the corporate domain, comparable effects on competitors' and audiences' decisions can be achieved, lawfully, through narrative framing, selective amplification of true information, algorithmic awareness, and precision influence. The tools of digital marketing—micro-targeting, A/B testing, emotional narrative design, and coordinated amplification—share their technical substrate with modern influence operations. That shared substrate is exactly why companies need both an offensive discipline bounded by law and ethics and a defensive discipline that recognizes when the same tools are turned against them.

NATO's scientific community has made cognitive warfare a formal research area. A 2020 study for NATO Allied Command Transformation's Innovation Hub argued that the human mind should be treated as an operational domain in its own right (du Cluzel 2020). The NATO Chief Scientist's research report on cognitive warfare goes further and summarizes NATO's recent definition: cognitive warfare is "the fight for Cognitive Superiority," in which contesting the environment comprises "deliberate, synchronized military and non-military activities throughout the continuum of competition designed to gain, maintain and protect cognitive advantage" (NATO STO n.d.). Readers of the original edition of this paper will recognize the parallel with its definition of Corporate Cognitive Warfare as the effort to "gain, maintain, and protect cognitive superiority." The same report describes three functions for research on cognitive warfare: to degrade adversaries' capabilities to influence, to improve human and technological cognition, and to be resilient, "withstanding and recovering" performance in the face of cognitive threats (NATO STO n.d.).

For a company, those three functions map to three questions. Can we reduce the effect of hostile or misleading narratives about us? Can we improve how our own people sense and decide? Can we absorb a cognitive attack, such as a viral falsehood, and recover quickly? Sections 6 and 8 are organized around those questions.

Further reading: NATO Chief Scientist Research Report on Cognitive Warfare

## 2.3 A Note on Method and Neutrality

The next three subsections describe how different military traditions conceptualize influence over perception and decision-making. Three cautions apply.

First, these are doctrinal and analytic concepts, described here from published sources. The paper does not assess whether any state has used them, how well, or to what effect, and it leaves out accounts of specific operations.

Second, much of the English-language literature on Russian and Chinese concepts is written by analysts working in or for Western defense institutions, often from translated sources. Some of those analysts themselves warn against over-reading. Keir Giles notes that the phrase "reflexive control" is "far more frequently encountered in recent Western writing about Russian information warfare principles than in original Russian sources" (Giles 2016). Peter Mattis argues that the "three warfares" are better understood as part of the Party's broader political work than as a narrowly military doctrine (Mattis 2018). Nathan Beauchamp-Mustafaga finds Chinese military thinking on psychological warfare "much more diverse than previously understood" (Beauchamp-Mustafaga 2023). Where such caveats exist, this paper reports them.

Third, the paper uses these concepts as lenses. What matters for a company is the underlying logic—how decisions can be shaped by the information environment around them—and what that logic implies for lawful competition and for defense.

## 2.4 Russian Reflexive Control Theory

### Origins

Reflexive control began as a mathematical and psychological theory before it became a military one. Its originator is generally identified as Vladimir A. Lefebvre, a Soviet researcher who worked within the logic of "reflexive games": models in which each party reasons about the other's reasoning, including the other's picture of itself (Vasara 2020; Thomas 2015). Lefebvre's 1967 book, published in Moscow, was translated into English as *Conflicting Structures* (Lefebvre 2015), and his work on reflexive systems appeared in English as *The Structure of Awareness: Toward a Symbolic Language of Human Reflexion* (Lefebvre 1977). Timothy Thomas, a long-time analyst at the U.S. Army's Foreign Military Studies Office (FMSO), records Lefebvre's early definition of reflexive control as "a process by which one enemy transmits the reasons or bases for making decisions to another" (Thomas 2015).

The definition most often cited in Western literature is the one Diane Chotikul gives in her 1986 Naval Postgraduate School study: reflexive control is "a means of conveying to a partner or an opponent specially prepared information to incline him to voluntarily make the predetermined decision" (Chotikul 1986). Thomas uses the same formulation and adds the phrase "desired by the initiator of the action" (Thomas 2015). Chotikul's study is notable for its method. Rather than analyze the mathematics, it sets out to place the theory in its historical and psychocultural context, in order to help Western analysts understand why the concept took the shape it did (Chotikul 1986).

### Development in military thought

Antti Vasara's 2020 study for the Finnish National Defence University traces the theory from Soviet cybernetics into military journals and later Russian strategy. He reports, for example, a 1971 article in the Soviet journal *Voennaya Mysl'* (*Military Thought*) by Major General M. Ionov, which held that an opponent can be persuaded to make decisions favorable to the other side when several conditions are met: the opponent is placed under pressure, influence is exerted on its situational assessment, on its decision-making algorithm and on the way it selects its goal, and influence is exerted on the timing of its decisions (Vasara 2020, citing Ionov 1971). Vasara's model divides reflexive control into *constructive* methods, which build a situational picture that leads the opponent toward a particular decision, and *destructive* methods, which disrupt or overload the opponent's decision process (Vasara 2020).

Thomas's 2004 article in *The Journal of Slavic Military Studies* remains a standard English-language survey of the concept and of the Soviet and Russian military authors who developed it (Thomas 2004). Thomas later cautioned that the most important lesson for students of Russian thought is to study what Russian military theorists actually say, rather than to force Western templates onto it (Thomas 2015). Keir Giles's handbook for the NATO Defense College describes reflexive control as "predetermining an adversary's decision" in one's favor "by altering key factors in the adversary's perception of the world." It compares the technique to "a skilful barrister cross-examining a witness," leading the other side through a series of decisions that successively close off options (Giles 2016).

Later Russian military writing places information and psychological effects at the center of conflict more broadly. In a 2013 article in *Military Thought*, S. G. Chekinov and S. A. Bogdanov wrote that "a new-generation war will be dominated by information and psychological warfare," which "will largely lay the groundwork for victory" (Chekinov and Bogdanov 2013). In a widely cited 2013 article, translated and republished by the U.S. Army's *Military Review* in 2016 "to acquaint our readers with the perspectives of senior Russian military leaders," General Valery Gerasimov wrote that "the role of nonmilitary means of achieving political and strategic goals has grown, and, in many cases, they have exceeded the power of force of weapons in their effectiveness" (Gerasimov 2016). A figure accompanying the translation depicts a 4:1 correlation of nonmilitary to military measures (Gerasimov 2016).

## Lessons for organizations

Stripped of its military context, reflexive control rests on four ideas that are useful to any strategist.

1. **Decisions are made inside a model.** Every decision-maker acts on a picture of the situation, of the options and of the other side. Changing the picture changes the decision.
2. **Model the other side's model.** Lefebvre's reflexive games treat strategy as recursive: I reason about how you reason about me. Competitive strategy that ignores how competitors and customers see the firm is strategy with a blind spot.
3. **The decision process has levers.** Ionov's conditions—pressure, situational assessment, decision rules, goal selection and timing—are a usable checklist for understanding why any audience decides as it does.
4. **The most effective influence feels self-generated.** The target "voluntarily" makes the decision. In commerce, this is the difference between pushing a message and helping a buyer reach a conclusion through evidence that the buyer finds credible.

The lawful corporate version of these ideas is familiar under other names: buyer-journey research, competitive war-gaming, scenario planning, pricing signals and category design. The firm works to understand how a buyer or competitor frames a decision and then supplies true, relevant information, such as a benchmark, a demonstration, a published commitment or a reference customer, that changes the frame. What the commercial version excludes is the "specially prepared" falsehood. A company that

feeds a competitor or a market fabricated information crosses from strategy into fraud, market manipulation or false advertising.

The defensive lesson matters just as much. If decisions can be steered by shaping the information around them, every organization's own decision process is an attack surface. Section 6 treats reflexive-control-style provocation, meaning attempts to bait a company into an overreaction that serves someone else, as a threat category. It also sets out "decision hygiene" practices that make an organization harder to steer.

Further reading: Thomas (2004), Russia's Reflexive Control Theory and the Military | Vasara (2020), Theory of Reflexive Control | Chotikul (1986), NPS study

## 2.5 Chinese Cognitive Domain Operations

### The "three warfares"

Analysts of Chinese military thought usually begin with the "three warfares" (三战): public opinion warfare, psychological warfare and legal warfare. Elsa Kania, writing in the Jamestown Foundation's *China Brief*, traces their formal adoption to the 2003 and 2010 Political Work Regulations of the People's Liberation Army (PLA), under the heading of "wartime political work," and to guidelines promulgated in 2005 that incorporated them into education and training (Kania 2016). In her summary, "in peacetime and wartime alike, the application of the three warfares is intended to control the prevailing discourse and influence perceptions" (Kania 2016). From the PLA texts she reviews, Kania concludes that the three warfares constitute a "perceptual preparation of the battlefield" (Kania 2016).

The U.S. Department of Defense's 2023 annual report to Congress describes the three components in parallel terms: public opinion warfare "creates and disseminates information to guide an adversary's public opinion and gain support from domestic and foreign audiences"; psychological warfare "uses propaganda, deception, and coercion to induce pressure and affect the behavior of the target audience"; and legal warfare "uses domestic and international laws to shape narratives" (U.S. DoD 2023). A 2013 study prepared for the Office of Net Assessment by Stefan Halper examined the concept in detail (Halper 2013). Peter Mattis, as noted above, cautions that the three warfares should be read as part of the Party's broader political work rather than as a narrowly military innovation (Mattis 2018).

The PLA Academy of Military Science's 2013 *Science of Military Strategy*, available in English through the China Aerospace Studies Institute's translation series, is one of the authoritative texts that analysts draw on for this material (PLA AMS 2013/2021; Kania 2016).

### From psychological warfare to cognitive domain operations

Since the late 2010s, Chinese military writers have discussed a broader concept: cognitive domain operations (认知域作战). Beauchamp-Mustafaga's 2019 analysis describes it as a "next-generation evolution of psychological warfare" that "seeks to use information to influence an adversary's cognitive functions, spanning from peacetime public opinion to wartime decision-making" (Beauchamp-Mustafaga 2019). The stated goal, in his account, is "mind superiority" (制脑权), which PLA writers present as following sea, air and information superiority as a condition of victory (Beauchamp-Mustafaga 2019). He also notes that the concept was "largely inspired by the U.S. military's emphasis on the cognitive domain's decisive role in modern warfare" (Beauchamp-Mustafaga 2019).

Josh Baughman of the China Aerospace Studies Institute (CASI) at Air University summarizes PLA Daily and Academy of Military Science writings on the subject. He quotes a PLA Daily definition of cognition as "the process by which people acquire, process, and apply information and knowledge," and an AMS formulation that cognitive domain operations "take people's will, belief, thinking, and psychology as direct combat targets, and seek to affect decision-making and actions by changing the opponent's cognition" (Baughman 2023). Baughman also notes that the cognitive domain was "not something uniquely Chinese," tracing the term to a 2001 U.S. Department of Defense report on network-centric warfare (Baughman 2023).

The AMS work Baughman reviews lists eight "operational characteristics." Two are directly relevant to the commercial lens. The first is competition for "Three Powers": the right to define the nature of an event, dominance of the event's process, and the right to judge its outcome (Baughman 2023). The second is the claim that "information moves faster than cannonballs," with social media treated as the main channel through which cognition is shaped (Baughman 2023). Whatever one thinks of the military application, the "Three Powers" are a precise description of what happens in any public controversy, product launch or crisis: someone defines what the event is, someone leads how it unfolds, and someone declares who won.

The 2023 DoD report describes cognitive domain operations as combining psychological warfare with cyber operations and modern communication platforms, "designed to achieve strategic national security goals by affecting a target's cognition," and notes PLA interest in incorporating AI, big data, brain science and neuroscience (U.S. DoD 2023).

## Technology and cognition

Several studies examine the role of emerging technology in this body of thought. Kania's 2019 article in *PRISM*, published by the U.S. National Defense University Press, examines PLA interest in brain science, AI and "human-machine hybrid intelligence" (Kania 2019). A 2021 CNA study on "intelligent warfare" by Kevin Pollpeter and Amanda Kerrigan reports that PLA writers "conclude that the cognitive domain will become more important in intelligent warfare," and that militaries will seek "to influence an adversary's perceptions through the denial, degradation, and manipulation of data and algorithms" (Pollpeter and Kerrigan 2021).

Beauchamp-Mustafaga's 2023 RAND report is the most detailed English-language treatment. Drawing on Chinese military books, journals and patent filings, it surveys PLA interest in big data, brain science and cognitive modeling for psychological warfare (Beauchamp-Mustafaga 2023). Its conclusions are measured. It finds that most of the next-generation capabilities surveyed, if realized, "are unlikely to fundamentally change Chinese strategic behavior." It identifies a different risk: that leaders might *believe* such technologies let them predict or shape adversary decisions, and so act with misplaced confidence (Beauchamp-Mustafaga 2023). That observation generalizes well beyond any one military. Confidence in one's ability to engineer other people's minds is itself a cognitive vulnerability.

## Lessons for organizations

Read neutrally, the Chinese literature contributes four ideas to the corporate lens.

1. **Perception is prepared in advance.** The idea of "perceptual preparation of the battlefield" implies that the contest for belief starts long before any crisis or launch. Companies that build trust, evidence and relationships in calm periods are better placed when contests begin.

2. **Narrative, psychology and rules work together.** The three warfares pair public opinion, psychological pressure and the use of law and rules to frame what is legitimate. The commercial counterpart is the integration of communications, persuasion and standards: industry certifications, benchmarks and regulatory submissions that establish what "good" means in a category.
3. **Contest the "Three Powers" lawfully.** Defining an event, leading its development and judging its outcome describes crisis communications and category leadership. A company does this lawfully by being first with accurate facts, transparent about what it is doing, and consistent in how it reports results.
4. **Beware the overconfidence trap.** RAND's caution about misplaced confidence applies to marketing technology. Psychographic models, attribution dashboards and generative tools can create an illusion of control over audiences who remain free and skeptical.

Further reading: Beauchamp-Mustafaga (2019), Cognitive Domain Operations | Beauchamp-Mustafaga (2023), RAND RR-A853-1 | Kania (2016), The PLA's Latest Strategic Thinking on the Three Warfares

## 2.6 NATO and Western Concepts

Western militaries have their own lineage of influence doctrine: psychological operations, information operations, strategic communications and, more recently, cognitive warfare as a field of study. NATO's work is notable for its defensive emphasis. The Chief Scientist's report states that cognitive warfare is "broader than InfoOps, PsyOps, STRATCOM, and cyber operations." It also stresses resilience—the ability to withstand and recover—as one of three core functions (NATO STO n.d.). The 2020 Innovation Hub study by François du Cluzel argued for recognizing a "human domain" of operations (du Cluzel 2020).

Taken together, the three traditions show a convergence. Each, in its own terms, treats the mind as contested terrain; each pays close attention to information technology as a multiplier; and each recognizes that influence operates in peacetime as well as in conflict. They differ in emphasis. Reflexive control focuses on steering an opponent's decision process. Cognitive domain operations stress the integration of narrative, psychology, law and technology across society. The NATO research agenda gives particular weight to resilience.

## 2.7 Comparative Synthesis

The table below sets the doctrinal concepts side by side with their lawful corporate analogues and the defensive implications for an organization.

| Concept (source) | Core idea | Lawful corporate analogue | Defensive implication |
|---|---|---|---|
| Reflexive control (Lefebvre; Chotikul 1986; Thomas 2004; Vasara 2020) | Shape the information and pressures behind another party's decision so it chooses "voluntarily" | Buyer-journey research, competitive war-gaming, credible public commitments, evidence that reframes a choice | Protect your own decision process: second sources, red teams, pause before reacting to provocations |
| New-generation war; nonmilitary means (Chekinov and Bogdanov 2013; Gerasimov 2016) | Information and psychological effects prepare the ground; nonmilitary means can outweigh force | Integrated communications strategy that leads with reputation, evidence and relationships | Expect contests to begin in the information space before any visible "attack" |
| Three warfares (Kania 2016; Halper 2013; U.S. DoD 2023) | Coordinate public opinion, psychological and | Combine PR, persuasion and standards (certifications, | Monitor narrative, sentiment and rule-setting |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | legal/rules-based framing | benchmarks, regulatory evidence) | arenas together, not separately |
| Cognitive domain operations (Beauchamp-Mustafaga 2019, 2023; Baughman 2023) | Target cognition and will across peace and conflict; contest the right to define, lead and judge events | Category design; first-with-facts crisis communication; transparent results reporting | Prepare to contest the framing of any incident within hours, with verified facts |
| Cognitive warfare research (du Cluzel 2020; NATO STO n.d.) | Treat the human mind as a domain; prioritize resilience | Employee and customer education; trust-building content; provenance standards | Build organizational resilience: inoculation, rapid correction, recovery plans |

### 2.8 Limits of the Analogy

Military doctrine is a lens, not a license. A company is not a state, its competitors are not enemies, and its customers are not targets in any hostile sense. Four differences constrain how far the analogy goes.

**Consent and choice.** Customers can walk away, and the law protects their right to make informed choices. Commercial influence that removes that choice through deception or manipulation is prohibited.

**Accountability.** Companies operate under consumer protection, competition, privacy, securities and platform rules, and their communications can be audited, litigated and regulated.

**Repeated games.** A company deals with the same customers, employees and regulators again and again. Trust compounds, and so does betrayal. Tactics that might "work" once are ruinous over many rounds.

**Transparency norms.** Much military influence doctrine assumes some secrecy. Commercial influence increasingly assumes the opposite: disclosure of paid relationships, labeling of AI-generated content, and transparency about targeting.

The value of the doctrine lies in its rigor. It forces disciplined thinking about terrain, audiences, decision processes, timing and resilience, and it makes plain what hostile actors may attempt against the organization.

## 3. Core Techniques and Tactics

The original paper identified five core techniques and a set of further irregular-warfare adaptations. This section keeps each description and adds, for each technique, its doctrinal logic, detailed lawful applications, the rules that bound it, and how to measure it. In keeping with the paper's ethics statement, wherever a technique has an illegitimate variant, that variant is named as a threat and handled in Section 6.

### 3.1 Guerrilla Marketing

Guerrilla marketing applies the logic of asymmetric irregular warfare: high-impact, low-resource actions that surprise, reframe, or embarrass larger competitors. Examples include ambush campaigns, experiential activations that generate organic narrative momentum, and rapid exploitation of

competitor missteps. Success depends on speed, local knowledge of audience psychology, and the ability to withdraw or pivot before costly counter-action.

**Doctrinal logic.** The term "guerrilla marketing" was popularized by Jay Conrad Levinson's 1984 book of that name, written for small businesses that could not outspend larger rivals (Levinson 1984). The parallel with irregular warfare is direct: concentrate scarce resources at the point and moment of greatest effect, rely on surprise and local knowledge, and avoid set-piece battles against superior budgets.

**Corporate applications.**

- **Category reframing.** Rather than compete on the incumbent's terms, a challenger names a new problem or a new standard and shows evidence that it matters. A security vendor might publish a free, reproducible assessment method for a risk the market under-weights. The method becomes the frame in which buyers then compare products.
- **Experiential activations.** Physical or digital experiences that people choose to share: a live demonstration at an industry event, a public challenge with transparent rules, a pop-up that solves a real problem. Activations should have the venue's and the city's permission, honor event rules, and avoid implying sponsorship that does not exist.
- **Newsjacking with substance.** When a relevant news event breaks, the fastest credible expert voice often defines the conversation. That means pre-approved spokespeople, a library of verified facts, and a rule that commentary adds information rather than exploiting tragedy.
- **Comparative challenger messaging.** Truthful, substantiated comparisons with named competitors are lawful in the United States and are encouraged by the FTC's policy statement on comparative advertising, provided they are clear and not deceptive (FTC 1979). Claims must be substantiated before publication, and comparisons must be like for like.
- **Rapid exploitation of competitor missteps—carefully.** When a competitor suffers an outage, price rise or policy change, a challenger can lawfully offer a migration path, a guarantee or an honest comparison. It must not spread rumors, exaggerate the competitor's problem or imply facts it cannot prove.
- **Community-first launches.** Seed a product with a small, highly engaged community, such as practitioners, user groups or open-source contributors, whose genuine enthusiasm carries further than paid reach.

**Boundaries.** Ambush tactics around major events can collide with trademark law and event-specific advertising restrictions. False or misleading claims about one's own or a competitor's products create liability under Section 43(a) of the Lanham Act (15 U.S.C. § 1125) and under Section 5 of the FTC Act, as explained in the FTC's Policy Statement on Deception (FTC 1983). Stunts that put the public at risk, trespass or deceive journalists destroy the legitimacy that guerrilla marketing depends on.

**Measures.** Share of voice in the target segment; earned-media mentions that carry the intended frame; inbound inquiries attributable to the activation; shift in the criteria buyers cite in sales conversations.

## 3.2 Marketing Psychological Operations (Persuasion Psychology)

Marketing psyops design messages to exploit cognitive biases, emotional triggers, and pre-existing belief structures. Techniques include fear-of-missing-out framing, social proof cascades, identity-based appeals, and controlled ambiguity. Unlike crude propaganda, effective corporate psyops maintain plausible alignment with brand values while systematically shifting perception thresholds.

In this expanded edition, "marketing psyops" means the disciplined, ethical use of persuasion psychology. The word "exploit" in the original description should be read in its strategic sense: to make full use of how people actually decide. It does not mean taking advantage of people against their interests. That distinction is the line between persuasion and manipulation, and it is the subject of active regulation.

**Doctrinal logic.** Military psychological operations aim to influence the emotions, motives and reasoning of selected audiences. The commercial counterpart rests on a large body of research on judgment and decision-making.

- **Framing.** Tversky and Kahneman showed that logically equivalent descriptions of a choice can produce different preferences depending on how outcomes are framed (Tversky and Kahneman 1981). Prospect theory shows that people weigh losses more heavily than equivalent gains (Kahneman and Tversky 1979).
- **Principles of influence.** Robert Cialdini's work describes recurring levers of persuasion—reciprocity, commitment and consistency, social proof, liking, authority, scarcity and, in the 2021 edition, unity (Cialdini 2021).
- **Psychological targeting.** Matz and colleagues showed in field experiments that tailoring persuasive appeals to people's psychological characteristics, inferred from digital footprints, changed their behavior. The authors warned that the same method "could be used to covertly exploit weaknesses in their character and persuade them to take action against their own best interest, highlighting the potential need for policy interventions" (Matz et al. 2017).

**Corporate applications.**

- **Loss framing of real risks.** A cybersecurity firm can truthfully frame the cost of inaction—downtime, regulatory exposure, recovery effort—using published data, rather than only describing features. Loss framing is legitimate when the loss is real and quantified honestly.
- **Genuine social proof.** Verified customer counts, named references with permission, independent reviews and case studies. Social proof is persuasive because people assume it is real, which is why fabricating it is unlawful (16 CFR Part 465).
- **Genuine scarcity and urgency.** Limited seats at a workshop, a real deadline for a price, an actual production run. False countdown timers and fake "only two left" messages are among the practices the FTC staff has identified as dark patterns (FTC 2022).
- **Authority through evidence.** Publishing methods, data and peer-reviewed or independently tested results, and letting credentialed experts speak in their own names.
- **Identity and unity appeals.** Speaking to the professional identity of an audience ("for the people who keep hospitals running"), communities of practice and shared values, without stereotyping or exclusion.
- **Commitment ladders.** Small, honest first steps—a free assessment, a pilot, a checklist—that let buyers test a claim before committing more. The buyer reaches the conclusion through their own experience, which is the ethical version of the "voluntary" decision at the heart of reflexive control.
- **Strategic ambiguity, properly bounded.** The original paper's "controlled ambiguity" is legitimate when it means leaving room for audiences to project their own aspirations onto a brand ("built for what's next"). It is illegitimate when vague language creates a false impression about price, performance or terms. Material terms must be clear.

**The persuasion–manipulation line.** A practical test for every persuasive technique: *Would the audience still make this choice if they fully understood what we did and why?* If yes, it is persuasion. If the

technique only works because the audience does not notice it—hidden fees, pre-checked boxes, confirm-shaming, disguised ads, obstruction of cancellation—it is manipulation, and regulators treat it as such (FTC 2022; FTC 1983).

**Measures.** Message-testing lift in comprehension and preference; change in stated decision criteria; complaint and refund rates as a guardrail metric (rising complaints signal persuasion tipping into manipulation).

## 3.3 Algorithmic Optimization ("Algorithmic Manipulation")

Modern platforms optimize for engagement. Corporate Cognitive Warfare treats ranking, recommendation, and discovery algorithms as contested terrain. The original edition of this paper used the term "algorithmic manipulation" for this terrain. In this expanded edition, the legitimate practice is described as **algorithmic optimization**: making truthful, useful content the path of least cognitive resistance by understanding how ranking and recommendation systems work and meeting their quality signals honestly. The objective is to make desired narratives the path of least cognitive resistance.

The original description listed tactics including "synthetic engagement networks (within platform rules)" and "the deliberate shaping of training data or trend signals." This edition narrows both. Synthetic engagement—fake accounts, purchased likes or views, automated networks posing as people—is prohibited by the major platforms and, where it creates fake indicators of social media influence, by the FTC's 2024 rule (X Corp. n.d.; YouTube n.d.; Meta n.d.; 16 CFR § 465.8). It is therefore treated in Section 6 as a threat. "Shaping training data" is legitimate only in the sense of publishing accurate, well-sourced, crawlable information about one's own organization. Planting false or misleading content to influence AI systems is a form of the data manipulation that the defense literature warns about (Pollpeter and Kerrigan 2021).

**Doctrinal logic.** Militaries treat the electromagnetic spectrum and information networks as terrain. For a company, ranking systems are terrain in the same sense: they determine what audiences see. The lawful approach is to understand the terrain, not to corrupt it.

**Corporate applications.**

- **People-first search content.** Google's guidance on "helpful, reliable, people-first content" and its spam policies describe what ranks and what is penalized (Google n.d.-a; Google n.d.-b). The spam policies define practices such as scaled content abuse ("many pages are generated for the primary purpose of manipulating search rankings and not helping users"), link spam (including "buying or selling links for ranking purposes") and cloaking. The lawful strategy is original research, expert authorship, clear structure, technical health and earned links.
- **Generative engine optimization (GEO).** AI assistants that synthesize answers from web sources are a new discovery layer. Aggarwal and colleagues introduced GEO as a framework for content creators and reported that GEO methods can "boost visibility by up to 40%" in generative engine responses, with effectiveness varying by domain (Aggarwal et al. 2024). The lawful takeaways are to publish clear, citable, well-sourced material: definitions, statistics with sources, quotations from named experts, and structured facts about the organization that an AI system can retrieve and attribute accurately.
- **Platform-native formats and cadence.** Each platform rewards different formats: short video, documents, threads, live sessions. Publishing in native formats, at times when the real audience is active, with accessible captions and alt text, is optimization without deception.

- **Authentic engagement design.** Content that invites substantive replies (questions, polls with real stakes, practitioner debates) earns genuine engagement signals. Engagement bait—content that exists only to solicit likes or shares—runs against platform policies (YouTube n.d.).
- **Owned discovery assets.** Newsletters, podcasts, communities and documentation that do not depend on any single algorithm. Irregular forces keep their own lines of communication.
- **Structured data and entity hygiene.** Consistent names, descriptions, leadership facts and contact details across the web reduce the chance that search engines and AI systems misstate who the organization is.

**A caution from the research.** In a study of rumor cascades on Twitter from 2006 to 2017, Vosoughi, Roy and Aral found that false news reached more people than the truth and spread faster, and suggested that novelty and the emotional reactions of recipients may help explain the difference (Vosoughi et al. 2018). Engagement-optimized systems can reward sensationalism. A company that chases engagement with exaggeration may win the moment and lose its credibility. The disciplined approach is to make true content as novel, clear and emotionally resonant as possible.

**Measures.** Organic visibility for priority topics; share of citations in AI-generated answers for category questions; engagement quality (saves, replies, shares by relevant accounts) rather than raw counts; accuracy of AI-generated descriptions of the company.

Related resource: Cognitive Warfare and Disinformation Economies (The Meridian, April 2026)

## 3.4 Social Influence Operations

Social influence campaigns identify and activate key nodes—creators, employees, analysts, community leaders—to propagate narratives organically. Methods include relationship mapping, incentive alignment, sharing of talking points, and the creation of self-reinforcing social proof. Authentic micro-influencers often outperform paid mega-endorsements because they carry higher perceived legitimacy.

**Doctrinal logic.** Irregular warfare is population-centric, and populations are networks. Granovetter's classic work on "the strength of weak ties" showed that acquaintances, not close friends, are often the bridges through which new information travels between groups (Granovetter 1973). Influence strategy therefore cares about bridges: the people who connect communities.

**Corporate applications.**

- **Relationship mapping.** Identify, from public information, the voices a target audience trusts: practitioners who write, conference speakers, community moderators, analysts, journalists. Map who bridges which communities. Respect privacy law when building such maps and use them to prioritize outreach, not to profile individuals invasively.
- **Creator partnerships with disclosure.** Paid or gifted creator relationships are lawful and effective when the material connection is disclosed clearly. The FTC's Endorsement Guides were revised in 2023 (16 CFR Part 255), and its *Disclosures 101 for Social Media Influencers* explains that disclosures must be clear and placed with the endorsement, not buried in a profile, in a pile of hashtags or behind a "more" link (FTC n.d.). Contracts should require disclosure, prohibit claims the brand cannot substantiate and allow the brand to monitor compliance.
- **Employee advocacy.** Employees are credible messengers. Programs that give staff accurate content to share are lawful when employees share voluntarily and identify their employment where they endorse the company's products. The Endorsement Guides treat employees'

connections as material connections that should be disclosed (16 CFR Part 255). Never script employees to pose as independent customers.

- **Analyst and expert relations.** Brief analysts with evidence, provide reference customers, and accept that independent experts will criticize. Paying for "independent" commentary without disclosure is deceptive.
- **Customer communities.** User groups, forums and councils where customers help each other build durable social proof. Moderate fairly, and never suppress negative reviews. Review suppression is a violation of the FTC's 2024 reviews rule (16 CFR § 465.7).
- **Talking points that equip rather than script.** Give advocates accurate facts, data and stories, then let them speak in their own words. Identical copy-pasted messages across many accounts look—and can be—coordinated inauthentic behavior.
- **Coalitions with transparent membership.** Industry associations and coalitions can lawfully advocate for shared positions, provided membership and funding are disclosed as the law requires. A coalition that hides its sponsors is astroturfing (Section 6).

**Measures.** Reach and engagement among priority communities; proportion of mentions coming from independent voices; sentiment among bridging nodes; disclosure compliance rate across partner content (target: 100 percent).

## 3.5 Targeted Paid Advertising

Precision advertising supplies the scalable delivery mechanism for cognitive effects. Behavioral and contextual targeting, sequential messaging, and dynamic creative optimization allow operators to deliver tailored narratives to specific decision-makers or audience segments. When integrated with organic and algorithmic efforts, paid media accelerates and protects narrative momentum.

The original description included psychographic targeting. That remains possible, but it is the area of targeting most constrained by law and most open to abuse (Matz et al. 2017). This edition treats it with corresponding care.

**Corporate applications.**

- **Account-based marketing (ABM).** In business-to-business markets, ads and content aimed at the members of a specific buying committee—finance, technical, executive—each addressing that role's real concerns with evidence.
- **Sequential messaging.** A planned narrative sequence: first the problem, then the evidence, then the proof, then the offer. Each step is truthful and stands on its own.
- **Contextual targeting.** Placing ads beside relevant content rather than relying on personal data. Contextual approaches reduce privacy risk and are increasingly effective as tracking declines.
- **First-party data with consent.** Audiences built from people who have chosen to engage (subscribers, event attendees, customers), with a clear lawful basis and honored opt-outs.
- **Dynamic creative optimization with guardrails.** Automated testing of headlines and visuals, constrained to pre-approved, substantiated claims so the optimizer cannot "discover" a misleading message that happens to perform well.
- **Defensive paid media.** Buying visibility on one's own brand terms and crisis-related queries so that accurate information appears where people look, especially during an incident.
- **Recruitment advertising.** Targeted employer-brand campaigns, subject to anti-discrimination law in employment advertising and to platform rules for employment ads.

**Boundaries.** In the EU, the GDPR requires a lawful basis for processing personal data, gives people an absolute right to object to direct marketing, and restricts processing of special categories of data such as

health, religion or political opinions (Regulation (EU) 2016/679). The Digital Services Act requires online platforms to show users that content is an advertisement, on whose behalf it is presented, and the main parameters used to target it. It prohibits ads based on profiling with special categories of personal data and profiling-based ads to users the platform knows with reasonable certainty are minors (Regulation (EU) 2022/2065, Articles 26 and 28). In California, the CCPA as amended by the CPRA gives consumers the right to opt out of the sale or sharing of their personal information, including through the Global Privacy Control (California DOJ n.d.). Platform advertising policies add further limits on sensitive targeting and categories. The practical rule: if a targeting choice would embarrass the company when explained to the person targeted, do not make it.

**Measures.** Incremental lift (measured with holdout tests, not attribution alone); cost per qualified opportunity; brand-search lift; opt-out and complaint rates as guardrails.

## 3.6 Additional Irregular Warfare Adaptations

- Intelligence preparation of the battlespace: systematic mapping of audience beliefs, competitor positioning, and information pathways, using lawful, public and consented sources.
- Disclosure discipline and counter-deception: deciding deliberately what to disclose and when, within securities, consumer and employment law, and protecting plans from leaks. The original edition listed "deception and misdirection." In lawful practice, a company may keep its plans confidential and choose the timing of truthful announcements. It may not make false statements, plant fake "leaks" or mislead markets. Detecting deception aimed at the company is a core defensive task (Section 6).
- Rapid adaptation cycles: continuous sensing and response loops that treat market feedback as real-time intelligence.
- Narrative defense and resilience: internal inoculation, monitoring of emerging threats, and pre-positioned counter-narratives built on verified facts.

## 3.7 Integrating the Five Techniques

The techniques are most effective as a combined system rather than as separate tools. The irregular-warfare analogy is combined arms: each element covers another's weakness.

- **Guerrilla actions create the spark.** They are cheap, surprising and newsworthy, but they fade quickly without follow-through.
- **Persuasion psychology shapes the message** so that the spark carries a clear, truthful frame instead of a forgettable stunt.
- **Algorithmic optimization extends reach and lifespan**, so that people searching or asking an AI assistant later find the same frame and the evidence behind it.
- **Social influence supplies credibility.** Independent and disclosed voices repeat the frame in their own words to the communities they bridge.
- **Targeted advertising adds precision and protection.** It puts the sequence in front of the specific decision-makers who matter, and holds the space on key queries during a crisis.

A simple integration test for any campaign plan: for each audience in the Understand map, can the team name the spark, the frame, the place the audience will find it again, the trusted voice who will confirm it, and the paid support that will reach the people who matter most? Gaps in that chain are where campaigns usually fail, and they are also where a competitor or hostile actor is most likely to move in.

# 4. Operational Framework

A practical Corporate Cognitive Warfare campaign follows a six-phase cycle:

1. Understand: map cognitive terrain, key audiences, belief systems, and information pathways.
2. Shape: design narratives and messages that use existing cognitive tendencies truthfully while remaining brand-consistent.
3. Seed: introduce content and talking points through organic, algorithmic, and paid channels, with every paid or material relationship disclosed.
4. Amplify: activate genuine social proof, disclosed advocates, and authentic algorithmic signals to achieve critical mass.
5. Protect: monitor for counter-narratives and adversary responses; adjust or inoculate.
6. Assess: measure changes in perception, decision criteria, and behavior; refine for the next cycle.

The cycle mirrors the military planning loop of intelligence, planning, execution and assessment. What makes it a *corporate* doctrine is that each phase passes through a gate: a short, explicit check that the work is truthful, disclosed, lawful and consistent with platform rules before it moves forward.

## 4.1 Phase Detail

**Understand.** Build an "intelligence preparation of the cognitive terrain." Inputs include customer interviews, win/loss analysis, search and social listening, analyst reports, review-platform content, AI-assistant answers about the category, and competitors' public statements. Outputs are an audience map (who decides, who influences, who bridges communities), a belief map (what each audience currently believes and why), a pathway map (where each audience gets information), and a threat map (who might contest the organization's narrative, and how). The reflexive-control lens adds a key question: how do the audience and the competitors model *us*?

**Shape.** Translate intelligence into a narrative architecture: one core proposition, three to five supporting claims, and the evidence for each. Each claim is checked for substantiation before it is used. Messages are tested for comprehension and persuasion with real members of the audience. The persuasion–manipulation test from Section 3.2 applies to every creative concept.

**Seed.** Introduce the narrative where the audience already is. Owned channels carry the full evidence. Earned channels—press, analysts, creators—carry independent validation. Paid channels add reach and sequence. Disclosures, consent and platform rules are built into the briefs, not added afterwards.

**Amplify.** Concentrate effort where momentum is forming. Bring in disclosed advocates, invite customers to share real experiences, answer questions in public, and put paid support behind content that is already performing organically. Amplification never includes fake accounts, purchased engagement or coordinated posting that misrepresents independence.

**Protect.** Monitor for hostile or mistaken narratives, impersonation, fake reviews and coordinated inauthentic activity. Prebunk known lines of attack, keep a verified fact base ready, and set response thresholds in advance (Section 6). Protect the organization's own decision-making from provocation.

**Assess.** Measure what changed in belief and behavior, not just in activity. Feed the lessons into the next cycle, retire claims that did not land, and record what the competition did in response.

## 4.2 Phase Gates and Outputs

| Phase | Key outputs | Gate question | Example measures |
|---|---|---|---|
| Understand | Audience, belief, pathway and threat maps | Was the intelligence gathered lawfully, from public or consented sources? | Coverage of priority audiences; freshness of data |
| Shape | Narrative architecture; tested messages | Is every claim true, substantiated and clear on material terms? | Comprehension and preference lift in testing |
| Seed | Channel plan; creator and partner briefs | Are all material connections disclosed and all targeting choices lawful? | Placement quality; disclosure compliance rate |
| Amplify | Advocate activation; paid support | Is all engagement authentic and every account real? | Share of voice; independent mentions |
| Protect | Monitoring; prebunks; response playbook | Are responses accurate, proportionate and pre-authorized? | Time to detect; time to verified response |
| Assess | Results review; lessons; next-cycle plan | Did we change beliefs without eroding trust? | Decision-criteria shift; trust and complaint metrics |

### 4.3 Metrics That Matter

Cognitive campaigns fail when they measure activity instead of effect. A useful metric stack has four layers:

- **Exposure:** reach, impressions, share of voice, share of AI-answer citations. Necessary, but never sufficient.
- **Perception:** awareness of the core proposition, association of the brand with the chosen frame, trust and credibility scores, sentiment among bridging voices.
- **Decision:** change in the criteria buyers use, inclusion in shortlists, win rates in contested deals, candidate acceptance rates, investor questions that reflect the intended narrative.
- **Integrity:** complaint rates, refund rates, regulatory inquiries, platform enforcement actions, disclosure compliance, and the accuracy of third-party descriptions of the company. Integrity metrics are guardrails: if they worsen while the others improve, the campaign is borrowing against trust.

### 4.4 Tempo

Irregular warfare rewards tempo, the ability to observe, decide and act faster than the opponent. In corporate terms, tempo comes from pre-approval. Spokespeople, fact bases, claim libraries, crisis holding statements and creator guidelines approved in advance let the team move in hours rather than weeks, without skipping the gates. Speed and compliance are not in tension when the compliance work is done before the race starts.

## 5. Use Cases

The twelve use cases below show the doctrine at work. They are illustrative composites, not accounts of real clients, campaigns or results. Each follows the same pattern: the situation, the objective, the approach, the guardrails and the measures of success.

## Use Case 1: The Challenger Reframes the Category

**Situation.** A mid-size software company competes with an incumbent whose brand dominates analyst reports and buyer shortlists. Head-to-head feature comparisons favor the incumbent's breadth.

**Objective.** Change the criteria buyers use, so that the challenger's real strength—time to value—becomes a deciding factor.

**Approach.** In the Understand phase, win/loss interviews show that buyers repeatedly complain about long implementations but never put implementation time in their requirements. The challenger publishes an open, reproducible method for measuring time to value, invites customers and competitors' customers to benchmark themselves, and releases anonymized aggregate results with its methodology. Sales teams use the method in discovery conversations. Analysts are briefed with the data. A sequential paid campaign aimed at operations leaders leads with the cost of delay, then the method, then customer evidence.

**Reflexive lens.** The incumbent's likely response is to dismiss the metric. The challenger anticipates this by making the method open and inviting independent replication, so a dismissal looks defensive.

**Guardrails.** All benchmark data is real, consented and methodologically documented. Comparative claims are substantiated before publication (FTC 1979).

**Measures.** Proportion of requests for proposals that include time-to-value criteria; shortlist inclusion; analyst mentions of the metric.

## Use Case 2: A Guerrilla Launch in a Crowded Consumer Market

**Situation.** A small consumer brand launches a durable product into a market saturated with heavily advertised alternatives.

**Objective.** Reach early adopters and earn credible word of mouth without a large media budget.

**Approach.** The brand runs a permitted public "durability challenge" at a busy venue, with transparent rules and live results. It seeds the product with micro-creators in relevant hobbyist communities, all of whom are contracted to disclose the relationship clearly. It opens a community forum where buyers can post genuine reviews, positive or negative.

**Guardrails.** Creator contracts require clear "#ad" or "sponsored" disclosures placed with the endorsement (FTC n.d.). No incentive is tied to positive sentiment, and no reviews are suppressed (16 CFR §§ 465.4, 465.7). The activation has venue and municipal permission.

**Measures.** Earned mentions; organic search growth for the brand name; review volume and rating distribution; repeat purchase rate.

## Use Case 3: Countering a Viral Falsehood About Product Safety

**Situation.** A manipulated video falsely suggesting a safety defect in a company's product spreads rapidly on social platforms.

**Objective.** Contain the falsehood, protect customers' trust, and contest the "right to define the event."

**Approach.** The Protect phase was prepared in advance: a monitoring service flags the spike within the hour, and a pre-approved response protocol is triggered. The company publishes a clear, evidence-based statement with test data and an independent laboratory's confirmation, reports the manipulated media to each platform under its policies, briefs journalists with verifiable facts, and answers customer questions directly. Following correction research, the response leads with the fact, explains why the claim is wrong, and avoids repeating the false claim more than necessary (Lewandowsky et al. 2012).

**Guardrails.** The company does not speculate about who made the video without evidence. Any legal action proceeds through counsel. Real safety concerns raised during the episode are investigated, not dismissed.

**Measures.** Time to detection; time to verified response; share of conversation carrying the correction; customer-service contact volume returning to baseline.

## Use Case 4: Defending Against a Fake-Review Attack

**Situation.** A regional services firm sees a sudden cluster of one-star reviews from accounts with no history, posted within hours and using similar wording.

**Objective.** Restore an accurate picture of customer experience and deter repetition.

**Approach.** The firm documents the pattern (timing, account age, text similarity), reports it to the review platforms with evidence, and responds publicly and politely to each review, inviting the reviewer to make contact with order details. It strengthens its genuine review pipeline by asking every real customer for honest feedback after service, without incentives tied to sentiment.

**Guardrails.** The firm does not retaliate with fake positive reviews, does not threaten reviewers, and does not suppress legitimate negative reviews—each of which would breach the FTC's rule (16 CFR Part 465).

**Measures.** Removal rate of reported reviews; trend in verified review volume; conversion rate from review-platform visits.

## Use Case 5: Winning the Talent Contest

**Situation.** A technology firm competes for scarce security engineers against larger employers with bigger brands.

**Objective.** Make the firm the preferred choice for a specific, high-value candidate segment.

**Approach.** Intelligence work shows that target candidates value interesting problems, learning time and flexible work more than headline salary. The firm's engineers publish technical write-ups under their own names, speak at practitioner conferences and run a public capture-the-flag event. An employee advocacy program offers optional, accurate content for staff to share.

**Guardrails.** Employees who post about open roles identify their employment. Participation is voluntary. Job ads comply with anti-discrimination rules, and targeting avoids protected characteristics.

**Measures.** Applications from the target segment; offer acceptance rate; time to hire; employee retention.

## Use Case 6: The Investor Narrative and Disclosure Discipline

**Situation.** A listed company plans a strategic shift that will depress near-term margins.

**Objective.** Help investors understand the strategy and its timeline so that the share price reflects long-term value rather than short-term surprise.

**Approach.** The company prepares a coherent narrative—why the shift, what milestones will show progress, and what risks remain—and discloses it publicly and simultaneously to all investors, consistent with Regulation FD (17 CFR Part 243). Management commits to reporting the same milestones every quarter, so the company keeps the right to "judge the outcome" credibly.

**Guardrails.** No selective disclosure of material nonpublic information, no misleading projections, and no "leaks" designed to move the price. Investor relations, legal and finance approve all materials.

**Measures.** Analyst models reflecting the stated milestones; volatility around announcements; quality of investor questions.

## Use Case 7: Lawful Engagement in a Policy Debate

**Situation.** A proposed regulation would affect an industry in which a company operates.

**Objective.** Ensure that regulators see accurate evidence about the regulation's effects.

**Approach.** The company submits public comments with data and methodology, joins an industry association whose membership is public, sponsors independent research with disclosed funding and no control over conclusions, and registers lobbying activity where the law requires it.

**Guardrails.** No fabricated grassroots campaigns, no form letters submitted under invented names, and no undisclosed funding of "independent" voices. Each of these is astroturfing (Section 6).

**Measures.** Inclusion of the company's evidence in the regulatory record; quality of the final rule from the company's perspective; reputation with regulators.

## Use Case 8: Account-Based Influence on a Buying Committee

**Situation.** An enterprise-services firm pursues fifty named target accounts with multi-person buying committees.

**Objective.** Shift each committee member's beliefs about the problem and the firm's credibility before a formal procurement begins.

**Approach.** For each role, the firm identifies the decisive fear and the evidence that addresses it: total-cost models for finance, technical proofs for engineering, peer references for executives. It runs role-specific sequential advertising, offers working sessions and invites committee members to private peer roundtables with existing customers.

**Guardrails.** Targeting uses business contact data with a lawful basis and honored opt-outs under the GDPR and the CCPA. No sensitive categories are used. All claims are substantiated.

**Measures.** Engagement by role within target accounts; meetings set; inclusion in requests for proposals; win rate.

## Use Case 9: Market Entry Into a New Country

**Situation.** A firm enters a market where it is unknown and where local competitors enjoy deep trust.

**Objective.** Earn legitimacy quickly.

**Approach.** The Understand phase studies local information habits, trusted institutions, regulatory expectations and cultural references. The firm hires local leaders who speak for it in their own names, partners with respected local institutions, localizes rather than translates its content, and makes visible commitments such as local support, data residency where relevant and community investment.

**Guardrails.** Full compliance with local advertising, privacy and consumer law; no claims about competitors that cannot be substantiated under local rules.

**Measures.** Aided awareness; trust measures relative to local competitors; partner and channel recruitment.

## Use Case 10: Executive Impersonation and Deepfakes

**Situation.** Fraudsters use a cloned voice of the chief financial officer to request an urgent payment, and a fake executive social-media account begins posting market-moving statements.

**Objective.** Prevent fraud, correct the record and protect market integrity.

**Approach.** The company's resilience plan already requires out-of-band verification for payment requests and a shared verification phrase for executives. Finance staff follow the procedure and the fraud fails. The communications team reports the impersonating account under platform policies, publishes the list of official accounts, and issues a statement through verified channels. Over time the company adopts content-provenance practices for official media, such as the Coalition for Content Provenance and Authenticity (C2PA) specifications (C2PA n.d.), and monitors for AI-generated content subject to labeling duties, such as those in Article 50 of the EU AI Act (Regulation (EU) 2024/1689).

**Guardrails.** Statements identify facts, not suspects, unless law enforcement confirms them.

**Measures.** Fraud attempts blocked; time to takedown; accuracy of media coverage.

## Use Case 11: Visibility in AI-Generated Answers

**Situation.** A professional-services firm finds that AI assistants describe its category without mentioning it, and sometimes misdescribe its services.

**Objective.** Ensure accurate, attributable representation in generative-engine answers.

**Approach.** The firm publishes well-structured explainers with clear definitions, sourced statistics and quotations from named experts; corrects inconsistent facts about itself across directories and profiles; and publishes original research that others cite. These steps reflect both people-first search guidance and GEO research on citability (Google n.d.-a; Aggarwal et al. 2024).

**Guardrails.** No mass-produced low-value pages (scaled content abuse), no purchased links, and no false claims planted to influence AI systems (Google n.d.-b).

**Measures.** Share of AI answers that cite or mention the firm for priority questions; accuracy of descriptions; referral traffic from AI surfaces.

### Use Case 12: The Internal Narrative During a Merger

**Situation.** After an acquisition, rumors about layoffs and culture clashes spread among employees of both companies, and competitors' recruiters circulate them.

**Objective.** Retain key people and maintain performance through integration.

**Approach.** Leadership treats employees as a priority audience. It publishes a clear integration timeline, commits to dates for decisions, holds open question sessions, equips managers with accurate answers, and sets up a channel where rumors can be raised and checked. Prebunking explains in advance the kinds of rumors that typically circulate during mergers and how to verify them (Roozenbeek et al. 2022).

**Guardrails.** Leaders do not promise what they cannot guarantee. Employment-law and works-council obligations are honored.

**Measures.** Regretted attrition; engagement-survey trust scores; rumor volume in the verification channel.

## 6. Defensive Operations and Counter-Influence

Every organization is already on contested terrain, whether or not it chooses to compete there. Competitors, activists, short sellers, fraudsters, disgruntled insiders and opportunists can all try to shape what the organization's audiences believe. Some will use lawful means. Others will use the deceptive tactics this paper excludes from legitimate practice. A cognitive defense capability is therefore as basic as cybersecurity, and the two increasingly overlap.

### 6.1 Threat Taxonomy

The Council of Europe's report on *information disorder* gives a useful vocabulary: mis-information is "when false information is shared, but no harm is meant"; dis-information is "when false information is knowingly shared to cause harm"; and mal-information is "when genuine information is shared to cause harm" (Wardle and Derakhshan 2017). The threats below combine these categories with the techniques of Section 3 turned to illegitimate ends.

- **Coordinated inauthentic behavior (CIB).** Networks of accounts that use false identities to mislead people about who is behind them and what they are doing. Meta's policies and threat reports describe and remove such networks, focusing on the deceptive behavior rather than the content (Meta n.d.).
- **Bot networks and fake engagement.** Automated or purchased accounts that inflate or attack metrics. Platform policies prohibit artificial engagement and coordinated manipulation (X Corp. n.d.; YouTube n.d.), and in the United States the FTC's 2024 rule prohibits the misuse of fake indicators of social media influence (16 CFR § 465.8).

- **Astroturfing.** Campaigns that pose as grassroots opinion while concealing a sponsor: fake petitions, front groups, undisclosed paid commentators, form letters under invented names.
- **Fake reviews and review manipulation.** Fabricated negative reviews of a target, or fabricated positive reviews of a rival, including AI-generated reviews. The FTC's rule addresses fake reviews, purchased reviews, undisclosed insider reviews, company-controlled review sites and review suppression (16 CFR Part 465).
- **Impersonation and deepfakes.** Fake executive accounts, cloned voices, manipulated video and spoofed domains used for fraud, market manipulation or reputational damage.
- **Narrative hijacking.** Taking over a company's hashtag, campaign or event to attach an unrelated or hostile message.
- **Data voids and AI poisoning.** Filling gaps in the information environment—queries for which little reliable content exists—with misleading material that search engines or AI assistants may then surface. The CNA study's observation that militaries may seek to influence perceptions through "manipulation of data and algorithms" has a commercial analogue (Pollpeter and Kerrigan 2021).
- **Malicious leaks (mal-information).** Genuine but selectively released documents, stripped of context to create a false impression.
- **Provocation (reflexive-control style).** Deliberate attempts to bait an organization into a visible overreaction—a hostile legal threat, an angry executive post, a public attack on a critic—that then becomes the real story. The reflexive-control literature describes influence on an opponent's situational assessment and the timing of its decisions (Vasara 2020). Pressure to "respond now" is often the lever.

## 6.2 A Shared Vocabulary: DISARM

Defenders benefit from describing influence campaigns in a common, structured way, as cybersecurity teams do with attack frameworks. The DISARM Foundation describes its open-source DISARM Red Framework as "a common language for documenting influence operations," so that organizations describing what they see "in the same terms" can share intelligence (DISARM Foundation n.d.). Mapping an incident to DISARM helps a company share information with platforms, peers and investigators, and check whether its defenses cover the techniques it is likely to face.

## 6.3 Detection: Narrative Sensing

The Protect phase depends on early warning. A narrative-sensing capability combines tools and human judgment:

- **Monitoring** of brand, executive, product and category terms across social platforms, forums, review sites, news and AI-assistant answers.
- **Baselines** of normal volume, sentiment and source mix, so anomalies stand out.
- **Indicators of coordination:** bursts of similar wording, newly created accounts, synchronized timing, unusual account networks and mismatches between claimed and observed location or language.
- **Triage** that asks three questions: is it false, is it coordinated, and is it gaining traction among audiences that matter?
- **Escalation thresholds** set in advance, so the team does not argue about whether to act while the narrative spreads.

## 6.4 Prebunking and Psychological Inoculation

Inoculation theory, developed by William McGuire in the 1960s, proposes that exposing people to a weakened form of a persuasive attack, together with a refutation, can build resistance to the full attack (McGuire 1964). Recent research has tested this approach against misinformation. Van der Linden and colleagues found that warning people about misleading tactics helped protect accurate beliefs about the scientific consensus on climate change (van der Linden et al. 2017). Roozenbeek and colleagues showed, in studies that included a field experiment on YouTube, that short videos explaining common manipulation techniques improved people's ability to recognize those techniques (Roozenbeek et al. 2022).

For organizations, prebunking means:

- Telling employees, customers and partners in advance about the kinds of scams, impersonations and false claims they may see, and how to verify official communications.
- Publishing a clear list of official accounts, domains and payment procedures.
- Explaining the organization's position on predictable controversies before they arrive, with evidence.
- Training staff to recognize manipulation techniques such as false urgency, fake authority and emotionally loaded framing.

## 6.5 Debunking and Correction

When false information is already circulating, research on correcting misinformation offers practical guidance. Lewandowsky and colleagues review why misinformation persists after correction and recommend, among other things, providing an alternative explanation that fills the gap left by the retracted claim, giving warnings before exposure where possible, and keeping corrections simple and focused on the facts (Lewandowsky et al. 2012). In corporate practice:

- **Lead with the truth** in clear, plain language, and give the audience a coherent account of what actually happened.
- **Show evidence** from sources the audience trusts: independent tests, regulators, customers.
- **Be fast but accurate.** A wrong correction is worse than a slow one. Pre-approved holding statements buy time.
- **Use the channels where the falsehood spread**, not only the company's own website.
- **Report and document** inauthentic activity to platforms under their policies, and preserve evidence for legal review.

## 6.6 Legal and Platform Remedies

Depending on jurisdiction and facts, remedies can include platform reporting under impersonation, CIB and fake-engagement policies; complaints to consumer-protection authorities about fake reviews or deceptive competitor advertising; actions for false advertising under Section 43(a) of the Lanham Act (15 U.S.C. § 1125); trademark and domain-dispute procedures for impersonation; and referrals to law enforcement for fraud. Legal action should be proportionate. An aggressive lawsuit against a critic can turn a minor story into a major one, which is precisely the provocation risk described above.

## 6.7 Decision Hygiene: Defending Against Reflexive Control

If an adversary's aim is to shape your decisions, the last line of defense is the quality of your own decision process. Practices that make an organization harder to steer include:

- **Second sources.** Never act on a single unverified signal, especially one that demands urgency.
- **Red-teaming assumptions.** Before major responses, ask: who benefits if we do this? What would an adversary want us to do now?
- **Pre-commitment.** Decide in calm conditions how the organization will respond to classes of events, so pressure in the moment has less leverage.
- **Pause rules.** For provocations, a short, deliberate delay to verify facts often removes the attacker's advantage.
- **Diverse inputs.** Include people with different information sources in crisis decisions to reduce shared blind spots.

## 6.8 Response Playbook

| Tier | Description | Typical response |
|---|---|---|
| 1. Watch | Low-reach false or hostile content; no coordination indicators | Log, monitor, prepare facts; no public response |
| 2. Engage | Growing reach among relevant audiences, or inaccurate claims by credible voices | Direct correction to the source; FAQ update; customer-service briefing |
| 3. Respond | Viral spread, coordination indicators, or impersonation | Public statement with evidence; platform reports; journalist briefings; legal review |
| 4. Crisis | Safety, financial or market-integrity impact; executive deepfake or fraud | Crisis team activation; regulators and law enforcement as appropriate; full-channel response; executive communication |

## 6.9 Organizational Resilience

NATO's research report treats resilience—the ability to withstand and recover—as a core function in countering cognitive warfare (NATO STO n.d.). For a company, resilience means a trust reserve built over time, employees who know how to verify and whom to tell, customers who know the official channels, documented processes for payments and approvals that do not rely on recognizing a voice, and leaders who rehearse cognitive-attack scenarios alongside cyber incidents. Organizations that plan for both find that the same people, the same fact base and the same calm process serve both.

## 6.10 Exercising the Defense

Defenses that are never tested decay. Infinitum recommends a regular program of authorized exercises, run with leadership approval and without deceiving the public:

- **Tabletop exercises** that walk the crisis team through a viral falsehood, a fake-review wave, an executive deepfake and a provocation designed to bait an overreaction, using the response tiers above.
- **Verification drills** in which finance and executive-support staff receive simulated urgent requests, clearly scoped and authorized in writing, to test out-of-band verification.

- **Monitoring tests** that check whether the narrative-sensing capability raises alerts on controlled test inputs, such as test mentions on the organization's own accounts or a monitoring vendor's test feed, within the expected time.
- **After-action reviews** that record what worked, what was slow and which pre-approvals were missing, then update the playbook.

The aim is the same as in security testing: find the gaps before an adversary does, under controlled conditions, with written permission.

# 7. Ethical and Legal Boundaries

Corporate Cognitive Warfare must remain within applicable laws governing advertising, competition, privacy, and securities disclosure. Techniques that involve outright fabrication of facts, coordinated inauthentic behavior that violates platform terms, or the deliberate targeting of vulnerable populations for harm fall outside legitimate practice. Organizations that sacrifice long-term trust for short-term cognitive gains typically destroy the very asset—reputation and legitimacy—that enables durable advantage.

Recommended safeguards include legal review of campaigns, transparency where required by regulation, clear internal policies distinguishing competitive framing from deception, and continuous monitoring for unintended societal effects.

## 7.1 The Regulatory Map

The table below summarizes the main rules that bound the techniques in this paper. It is a map, not legal advice. Requirements vary by jurisdiction and change over time, and campaigns should be reviewed by qualified counsel.

| Rule | What it covers | Relevance |
|---|---|---|
| FTC Act § 5; FTC Policy Statement on Deception (1983) | Deceptive acts or practices in commerce | All claims, framing and interface design |
| FTC Endorsement Guides, 16 CFR Part 255 (revised 2023) | Endorsements, testimonials, disclosure of material connections | Creators, employees, affiliates, experts |
| FTC Rule on Consumer Reviews and Testimonials, 16 CFR Part 465 (effective 2024) | Fake reviews, purchased reviews, insider reviews, review suppression, fake social-media indicators | Review programs; social proof; engagement metrics |
| FTC Statement on Comparative Advertising, 16 CFR § 14.15 | Truthful comparisons naming competitors | Challenger messaging |
| Lanham Act § 43(a), 15 U.S.C. § 1125 | False or misleading representations; false association | Competitor claims; ambush marketing |
| SEC Regulation FD, 17 CFR Part 243 | Selective disclosure of material nonpublic information | Investor narratives |
| EU GDPR, Regulation (EU) 2016/679 | Lawful basis, special categories, right to object to direct marketing | Targeting; data-driven persuasion |
| EU Digital Services Act, Regulation (EU) 2022/2065 | Ad transparency; limits on profiling-based ads | Paid media on platforms in the EU |
| EU AI Act, Regulation (EU) 2024/1689, Art. 50 | Transparency duties, including disclosure of deepfakes | Synthetic media in campaigns |
| EU Unfair Commercial Practices Directive 2005/29/EC | Misleading and aggressive commercial practices | Consumer marketing in the EU |
| CCPA as amended by CPRA (California) | Rights to know, delete, correct and opt | Targeting; data use |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | out of sale or sharing | |
| ICC Advertising and Marketing Communications Code (2024) | Self-regulatory standards, including AI, influencer marketing and disinformation | Global baseline for responsible marketing |
| Platform policies (Meta, X, YouTube, LinkedIn, Google Search) | Inauthentic behavior, fake engagement, spam, impersonation | All organic and paid platform activity |

### 7.2 Red Lines

The following practices are outside Corporate Cognitive Warfare as Infinitum defines it, whatever their short-term effect:

- Fabricating facts, data, reviews, testimonials or endorsements.
- Creating or buying fake accounts, bot networks or artificial engagement.
- Concealing a sponsor behind a "grassroots" campaign, front group or undisclosed paid voice.
- Impersonating people, organizations or official bodies, including through synthetic media.
- Spreading false or misleading claims about competitors, critics or public issues.
- Planting false information to influence search engines or AI systems.
- Designing interfaces that trick people into choices they would not otherwise make.
- Targeting children, people in crisis or people defined by sensitive characteristics with manipulative techniques.
- Selectively disclosing material nonpublic information, or planting leaks to move markets.
- Harassing, threatening or doxxing critics, journalists or competitors' staff.

### 7.3 The Ethics Test

Legal compliance is the floor. Four questions help teams decide whether a lawful tactic is also wise:

1. **Transparency:** Would we be comfortable if the audience knew exactly what we did and why?
2. **Truth:** Is every claim true and substantiated, and is the overall impression accurate?
3. **Autonomy:** Does the tactic help people decide, or does it work by stopping them from thinking?
4. **Durability:** Will this build or erode trust if we do it a hundred times?

A tactic that fails any of these questions should be redesigned or dropped.

### 7.4 Governance

Ethics needs a mechanism. Recommended governance includes a written Corporate Cognitive Warfare policy approved by leadership; a standing review group spanning marketing, communications, legal, privacy and security; documented substantiation files for claims; disclosure checklists for all partner content; a register of campaigns that use personal data, with their lawful basis; periodic audits of creator and affiliate compliance; and a confidential channel through which staff can raise concerns about tactics without fear of reprisal.

## 8. Implementation Considerations

Successful adoption requires cross-functional integration of marketing, communications, competitive intelligence, legal, and executive leadership. Organizations should invest in narrative sensing capabilities, rapid response protocols, and personnel trained in both influence design and ethical restraint. Smaller

firms can achieve outsized effects by concentrating on high-leverage cognitive nodes rather than attempting broad-spectrum campaigns.

## 8.1 The Cognitive Cell

Infinitum recommends a small, cross-functional "cognitive cell" rather than a new department. A typical cell includes:

- **Lead** (often the chief marketing or communications officer), accountable for the narrative strategy and integrity metrics.
- **Intelligence analyst**, responsible for audience, belief, pathway and threat maps and for competitive intelligence from lawful sources.
- **Narrative and creative lead**, responsible for message architecture and testing.
- **Channels lead**, covering organic, algorithmic and paid distribution.
- **Trust and safety analyst**, responsible for monitoring, coordination detection and platform reporting.
- **Counsel and privacy partner**, who reviews claims, disclosures and data use.
- **Security liaison**, linking cognitive threats such as impersonation and deepfakes with cybersecurity operations.

## 8.2 The First 90 Days

**Days 1–30: Understand and protect.** Build the first audience, belief, pathway and threat maps. Set up monitoring and baselines. Publish official channels and verification procedures. Write the Corporate Cognitive Warfare policy and the red lines.

**Days 31–60: Shape and prepare.** Develop the narrative architecture and claim library with substantiation files. Pre-approve spokespeople and holding statements. Draft the response playbook and run a tabletop exercise that includes a deepfake and a fake-review scenario.

**Days 61–90: Seed, amplify, assess.** Launch the first campaign cycle on a focused objective. Activate disclosed advocates. Measure exposure, perception, decision and integrity metrics. Hold a lessons-learned review and plan the next cycle.

## 8.3 Maturity Path

| Level | Description |
|---|---|
| 1. Reactive | Marketing and communications operate separately; no monitoring; crises handled ad hoc |
| 2. Aware | Basic monitoring and a crisis plan exist; audience research is occasional |
| 3. Integrated | A cognitive cell runs the six-phase cycle; gates and integrity metrics are in place |
| 4. Resilient | Prebunking, decision hygiene and joint cyber–cognitive exercises are routine; response tiers are rehearsed |
| 5. Leading | The organization shapes category standards and is a trusted source for its audiences, platforms and peers |

## 8.4 Training

Training should cover persuasion psychology and its ethical limits; disclosure and privacy rules; platform policies; recognition of coordinated inauthentic behavior and synthetic media; correction techniques; and decision hygiene under pressure. Executives need a short version focused on provocation risk, verification and the authority to pause.

### 8.5 Working With Infinitum Corporation

For consulting, training, or red-teaming support on Corporate Cognitive Warfare, contact William Aaron Turner at Infinitum Corporation. Infinitum's red-teaming in this field is defensive: authorized exercises that test how an organization detects and withstands hostile influence, impersonation and fake engagement, conducted with written permission and without deceiving the public.

## Conclusion

Corporate Cognitive Warfare, as coined by William Aaron Turner, names a reality that already exists in modern markets: competition for attention, belief, and decision-making is as decisive as competition for capital or distribution. By systematically applying irregular warfare principles—guerrilla agility, psychological precision, algorithmic awareness, and social influence—organizations can achieve durable cognitive advantage while remaining within ethical and legal bounds.

The organizations that master the cognitive domain will not merely sell more effectively; they will shape the conditions under which customers, talent, investors, and competitors make choices. In an age of abundant information and scarce attention, cognitive dominance is the ultimate form of market power.

The expanded edition adds a final point. The military traditions surveyed in Section 2 differ in vocabulary and purpose, but they agree that the mind is terrain, that information technology multiplies influence, and that the contest continues in peacetime. They also show the limits of influence. Analysts caution against overconfidence in engineering other people's decisions, and NATO's research emphasizes resilience. For a company, the lesson is balance. Compete hard for attention and belief with truthful, disclosed, lawful means. Defend the organization's audiences and its own decision-making against those who do not follow the rules. Treat trust as the center of gravity, because in a repeated game it is the one advantage competitors cannot copy quickly.

*— End of White Paper —*

*Term “Corporate Cognitive Warfare” coined by William Aaron Turner, 2026.*

## About Infinitum Corporation

Infinitum Corporation is a technology and security consulting firm headquartered in Washington, DC (1629 K Street NW, Suite 300, Washington, DC 20006), with Moscow as an operating location. It provides cybersecurity consulting, network defense, ethical hacking and vulnerability assessment, AI applications for security operations, strategic risk assessment, defense technology advisory and Corporate Cognitive Warfare. Open Monday–Friday, 9:00 AM–9:00 PM; closed Saturday and Sunday.

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**About the author.** William Aaron Turner is the Founder and President of Infinitum Corporation. He coined the term "Corporate Cognitive Warfare" in 2026.

**Disclaimer.** This white paper is for general information. It is not legal advice. Use cases are illustrative composites and do not describe real clients or results. References to military doctrine are analytical and neutral and imply no endorsement of any state, organization or policy. © 2026 Infinitum Corporation.

## Glossary

- **Astroturfing:** a campaign that poses as spontaneous grassroots opinion while concealing its sponsor.
- **Cognitive domain operations:** a concept in Chinese military writing for operations that target cognition, will and decision-making across peacetime and conflict.
- **Coordinated inauthentic behavior (CIB):** networks of accounts that use false identities to mislead people about who is behind them.
- **Decision hygiene:** practices that protect an organization's decisions from manipulation, such as second sources, red-teaming and pause rules.
- **Disinformation:** false information knowingly shared to cause harm.
- **Generative engine optimization (GEO):** improving the visibility and accurate attribution of content in AI-generated answers.
- **Inoculation (prebunking):** warning people about manipulation techniques or false claims in advance so they can resist them.
- **Mal-information:** genuine information shared to cause harm, often stripped of context.
- **Material connection:** a relationship between an endorser and a brand (payment, free products, employment) that could affect how an audience weighs the endorsement.
- **Reflexive control:** a Soviet and Russian theory of conveying specially prepared information to incline another party to make a predetermined decision voluntarily.
- **Three warfares:** public opinion warfare, psychological warfare and legal warfare, as described in Chinese military writing.

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All sources below are public. Journal articles were checked against their DOI records (Crossref). Reports, statutes and policies were opened at the URLs given, or, where a government site blocks automated

access, confirmed through the publisher's listing, between October 30 and 31, 2026. Where a primary source is cited through a secondary work, the entry says so.

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